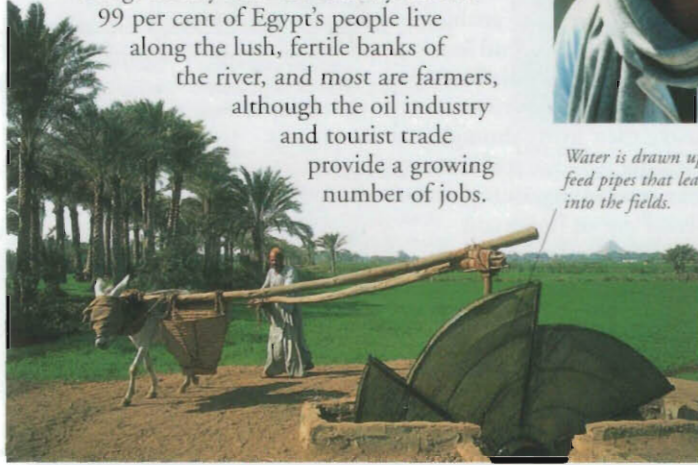


Egypt

 Today, as throughout its 5,000-year history, Egypt depends on the River Nile for much of its water, food, transport, and energy now generated at the massive Aswan Dam. Egypt controls the Suez Canal, an important shipping route that links Africa, Europe, and Asia, and brings money into the country. About

99 per cent of Egypt's people live along the lush, fertile banks of the river, and most are farmers, although the oil industry and tourist trade provide a growing number of jobs.



Water is drawn up to feed pipes that lead into the fields.

Farming

Egypt is one of the world's leading producers of dates, which are mostly grown in oases, along with melons. While some farmers use modern methods, many *fellahin*, or peasant farmers, use centuries-old techniques such as this one, where the donkey drives a wheel that scoops up water for irrigation.



Ful medames

Food

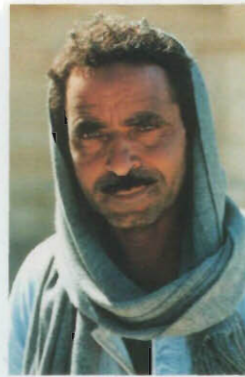
Reputed to be as old as the Pyramids, the traditional Egyptian dish of *ful medames* is made by boiling broad beans with garlic, onion, olive oil, and spices. The beans are served with hard-boiled eggs, lemon, and unleavened bread. Food is often accompanied by sweet tea and coffee.



The Sultan Hassan Mosque and surrounding area

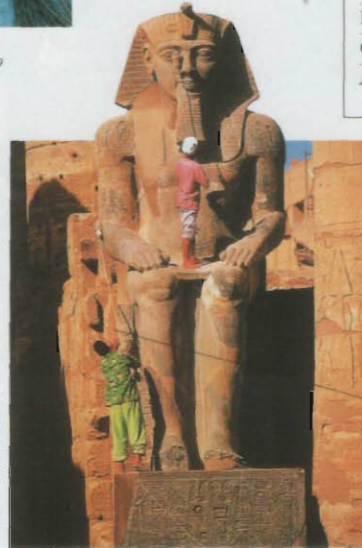
Cairo

Egypt's ancient capital is the largest city in Africa, with a population of more than 7,000,000. It has at least 1,000 mosques, some built with stone looted from the Pyramids. Old Cairo's narrow streets heave with bustling bazaars, while the wealthy west bank has modern casinos and hotels.



People

Several ethnic groups live in Egypt. Most people speak Arabic, but there are Berber and Nubian minorities. Until recently urban women were among the most liberated in the Arab world, but that may change with the rise of Islamic fundamentalism. In rural families, men go out to work, while women cook and fetch water.



Ramesses II statue, Temple of Luxor

EGYPT FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Cairo
AREA	995,450 sq km (384,343 sq miles)
POPULATION	68,500,000
DENSITY	69 people per sq km (154 per sq mile)
MAIN LANGUAGE	Arabic
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Egyptian pound
LIFE EXPECTANCY	67 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	625
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	55%

Tourism

Millions of people flock to Egypt every year to see the Pyramids and other remains of the country's ancient past, such as the tombs in the Valleys of the Kings and Queens, and the temples at Karnak and Luxor. The oldest pyramid is the Step Pyramid at Saqqara, which was built about 2650 BC as a tomb for King Zoser.

Soft dusters on poles are used to clean the delicate sandstone.

Cotton plant

Cotton

Although only five per cent of Egypt's land can be farmed, the country is a leading producer of cotton. Quality cloths are exported or made into cool garments like *jellebas*, or tunics, often worn by locals.

Cotton boll



Suez Canal

More than 20,000 cargo ships sail through the Suez Canal each year. The canal, built by French engineers in 1869, is 190 km (118 miles) long and provides a short cut for ships between the Gulf of Suez and the Mediterranean Sea.

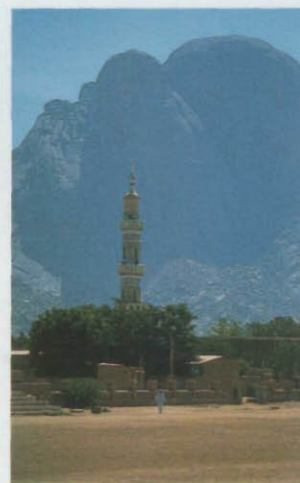
Sudan

 Sudan is the largest country in Africa, measuring 2,050 km (1,274 miles) long from north to south. Desert in the north gives way to a central, grassy plain. Marshland covers much of the south. Two branches of the Nile (the White Nile and the Blue Nile) meet at the capital, Khartoum, providing fertile soil for farming. The country has good oil and mineral resources, but war and drought have weakened it.



People

There are more than 500 Sudanese ethnic groups, speaking about 100 languages and dialects. Some are nomadic herders, many of whom have now settled on farms. Most own their own plots, and live in villages of mud huts along the Nile, where farming is combined with fishing. The produce is sold at markets. Civil war and famine in the south of Sudan have created refugees.



SUDAN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Khartoum
AREA	2,376,000 sq km (917,374 sq miles)
POPULATION	29,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Arabic
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, traditional beliefs, Christian
CURRENCY	Sudanese pound or dinar

Religious conflict

The ruling people of the north are Arab Muslims, and the tall minarets of their beautiful mosques dominate the landscape. Farther south, the majority are divided into many ethnic groups and follow Christianity or traditional African religions. The religious, cultural, and language differences between north and south have caused bitter fighting.